

Luigi Cherubini was born in Florence in 1760 and began learning music at the age of six; by the time he was 13 years old, he was composing his own works. In 1778, aged 18, Cherubini began a three-year apprenticeship with Giuseppe Sarti in Bologna and Milan, where he learned counterpoint and dramatic composition. His first opera, *Quinto Fabio*, appeared in 1780 and led to opera commissions throughout Italy. Then, in 1784, he was contracted as a house composer at the King's Theatre in London, where he presented four operas, the first of which was *Demetrio* (premiered 1785).

A major move

The following year Cherubini moved to Paris, where he was to remain for the rest of his life. During his first six years in the capital, he shared an apartment with the violinist Giovanni Battista Viotti, who introduced him to Queen Marie Antoinette and to leading musicians of the day. His first commission for the Paris Opéra was *Démophon* (1788), written the year before the French Revolution brought turmoil to the city (see [box](#)).

Cherubini soon became a major figure in Paris—as a conductor and teacher as well as a composer. His works of the revolutionary period were often somber and austere. But in 1791 his *Lodoïska*, a form of opéra comique, premiered at the Théâtre Feydeau in Paris. Mixing comic and serious themes, and featuring ordinary people, its depiction of heroism captured the revolutionary spirit and was an early example of “rescue opera” (here, the heroine is rescued from a castle by a servant). Outstandingly popular, it became his first international